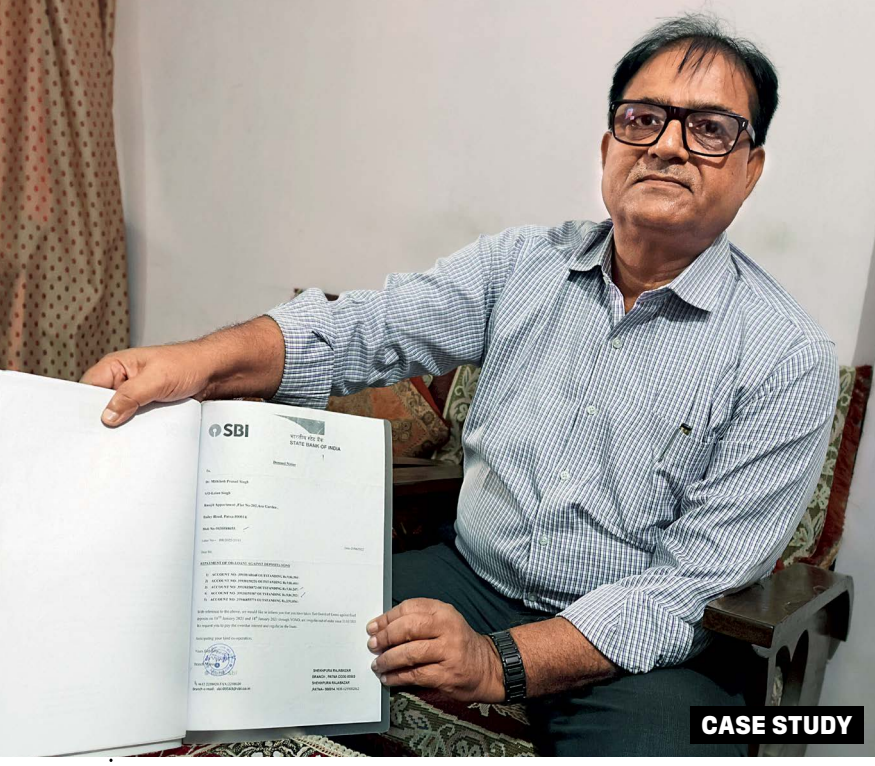


CASE STUDY

RANJAN RAHI

A SIMple Duplicity

AURANGABAD, Bihar

DR MITHILESH KUMAR SINGH, 63

District Immunisation Officer

Sum lost
Rs 43.36 lakh

Victim of
FD fraud

In June 2022, Singh received a letter from his bank, asking him to regularise payments against his five overdraft loans totalling Rs 43.36 lakh against his bank FD. Having no recollection of any such loan, Singh rushed to his bank. He was told that a new phone number had been added to his account in January 2021, and was used to download the SBI Mobile application through which the loan was processed. Singh immediately filed an FIR, and police investigations revealed that the fraudsters had taken control of his account and net banking password, and used the money to buy gold. Singh did get his FD released after two months, following an internal probe by the bank, but minus the amount that had been siphoned off. Since the police were unable to trace the crooks, the economic offences wing has now taken over the case. ■

-Amitabh Srivastava

read their phone

↘ Requesting them to make a token payment via Paytm or net banking to lift the PIN or password

↘ Getting them to scan a QR code that debits money from their account

↘ Swiftly withdrawing money at ATMs from a bank account on hire.

BAITING THE QUARRY

The old phishing/ smishing tactics of yore, which prey on such human frailties as greed, fear or vulnerability, continue to thrive. They involve sending bulk e-mails or SMSes offering threats—from electricity disconnection to bank account suspension for incomplete KYC documents—or inducement, such as a lottery win or a job offer. The Telegram app is one more arena where this fraud is played out, offering payments for different tasks such as a film review, YouTube likes and odd jobs. The fraudulent text typically has a link, clicking which instals Trojan malware in your device that allows the criminal untrammelled access to it, or a fake phone number, dialling which leads you into the fraudster's web.

Phishing acquired an added dimension with the advent of "voice and telephony", giving rise to vishing. It allowed cyber attackers to establish direct contact with their targets and use 'social engineering' (cyberspeak for psychological manipulation) techniques to extract Aadhaar or PAN details, PINs and passwords, debit or credit card CVVs, and then use these to empty bank accounts.

Over time, as criminals realised how low risk and high return such con jobs were, their frauds became more elaborate. Deepti Tyagi (*name changed*), a 53-year-old media professional, was the victim of one such fraud. It began with a fake cash on delivery package. When she called what she thought was the customer care number of the delivery company that brought her the package she hadn't ordered, the 'executive' at the other end of the line assured her of all the help. All she had to do was download an app called ISL Light and then make a small test payment of Rs 10, and her problems would be sorted forever. What the crook did instead was gain access to her phone and use her Paytm PIN to siphon off Rs 1 lakh, sending Tyagi scurrying to freeze her account and report the cyber theft.

Fake customer care support is, in fact, a booming business. You'll find these customer care numbers everywhere—in your mailbox, phone messages, Facebook ads and on spoofed websites of banks and e-commerce portals that pop up thanks to smart search engine optimisation. In a report earlier this year, Bengaluru-based cyber security firm CloudSEK flagged 31,179 such